

SAUDI ARABIA

Key Country Details: Saudi Arabia

Detail	Information
Full Name	Kingdom of Saudi Arabia
Short Form	Saudi Arabia
Capital	Riyadh
Region (UN)	Asia-Western Asia
Government Type	Absolute Monarchy
Head of State	King Salman bin Abdulaziz Al Saud
Head of Government	Crown Prince and Prime Minister Mohammed bin Salman
Currency	Saudi Riyal (SAR)
UN Member Since	1945
MUN Standing	Active contributor in OPEC and regional stability debates, often defends conservative social policies and sovereignty-based approaches.

Recommended Books on Saudi Foreign Policy, UN Engagement & Region

1. **"Saudi Arabia and the United States: Birth of a Security Partnership"** – Aaron David Miller
2. **"Saudi Arabia in Transition: Insights on Social, Political, Economic and Religious Change"** – Bernard Haykel et al.
3. **"The Foreign Policies of Middle East States"** – Raymond Hinnebusch & Anoushiravan Ehteshami
4. **"Inside the Kingdom: Kings, Clerics, Modernists, Terrorists, and the Struggle for Saudi Arabia"** – Robert Lacey
5. **"Desert Kingdom: How Oil and Water Forged Modern Saudi Arabia"** – Toby Craig Jones

Research Table: Saudi Arabia & UNHRC

Source Name	Link	Why It's Useful
OHCHR Saudi Arabia Page	https://www.ohchr.org/en/countries/saudi-arabia	Human rights treaties, reviews, and documents
Saudi Arabia Human Rights Commission	https://www.hrc.gov.sa	State-sanctioned human rights perspective
Human Rights Watch KSA Reports	https://www.hrw.org/middle-east/n-africa/saudi-arabia	Focuses on systemic human rights violations
Amnesty International KSA Profile	https://www.amnesty.org/en/location/middle-east-and-north-africa/saudi-arabia/	Details on civil rights and advocacy cases
Freedom House Saudi Arabia Report	https://freedomhouse.org/country/saudi-arabia/freedom-world/2024	Quantitative civil liberties ranking

UN Special Rapporteur Reports – KSA	https://www.ohchr.org/en/special-procedures-human-rights-council	Independent assessments of rights issues
U.S. State Dept Human Rights Report on KSA	https://www.state.gov/reports/2023-country-reports-on-human-rights-practices/saudi-arabia/	Key diplomatic human rights review
Gulf Centre for Human Rights	https://www.gc4hr.org	Monitors repression of activists in Saudi Arabia

Source Name	Link	Why It's Useful
OHCHR – Saudi Arabia Country Profile	https://www.ohchr.org/en/countries/saudi-arabia (ohchr.org)	Baseline UN info on national treaty status, technical cooperation, and HRC engagement.
OHCHR – Saudi Arabia UPR Hub	https://www.ohchr.org/en/hr-bodies/upr/sa-index	Central repository for government, stakeholder, and outcome reports.
HRW – UPR Submission (2023)	https://www.hrw.org/news/2023/07/20/submission-universal-periodic-review-kingdom-saudi-arabia	NGO critique highlighting ongoing repression, jailings, Khashoggi case, and Yemen actions.
Amnesty – UPR Submission (2023 PDF)	https://www.amnesty.org/en/documents/mde23/6936/2023/en/	Detailed submission on censorship, female rights, migrant abuse, and penal code issues.
HRW – World Report 2024	https://www.hrw.org/world-report/2024/country-chapters/saudi-arabia	Covers migrant killings, social media punishment, political detentions.
OHCHR SR on Counter-Terrorism Visit	https://www.ohchr.org/en/countries/saudi-arabia	Features Special Rapporteur's report on counter-terrorism and rights restrictions.

OHCHR – Technical Cooperation Profile	https://www.ohchr.org/en/countries/middle-east-north-africa/technical-cooperation-saudi-arabia	Describes OHCHR-led human rights capacity programs since 2014.
State Dept – HR Report 2023 (PDF)	https://www.state.gov/wp-content/uploads/2024/02/528267-SAUDI-ARABIA-2023-HUMAN-RIGHTS-REPORT.pdf	US government evaluation of rights violations, including extrajudicial killings.
Amnesty – UPR Submission 2018 PDF	https://www.amnesty.org/en/wp-content/uploads/2021/05/MDE2386732018ENGLISH.pdf	Analysis on suppression of dissent, women's rights, migrant worker treatment.
HRW – UPR Submission (2013 PDF)	https://upr-info.org/sites/default/files/documents/2013-10/aisauups42009amnestyinternational.pdf	Historical context of systemic violations affecting multiple groups.
HRW – UPR Submission 2018	https://www.hrw.org/news/2018/03/29/submission-universal-periodic-review-saudi-arabia	Details on torture, migrant labor, rights of women/minorities.
Freedom House – 2024 Profile	https://freedomhouse.org/country/saudi-arabia/freedom-world/2024	Analysis of civil/political freedoms—relevant for UNHRC thematic reviews.
OHCHR – Treaty Ratification Status	https://tbinternet.ohchr.org/_layouts/15/TreatyBodyExternal/Countries.aspx?CountryCode=SAU&Lang=EN	Tracks ratification of core UN human rights treaties.
OHCHR – Stakeholder Contributions (UPR)	https://www.ohchr.org/en/hr-bodies/upr/uprsa-stakeholders-info-s31	Collection of NGO and UN stakeholder inputs for UPR cycle.
OHCHR – Extreme Poverty Visit Report (2017)	https://www.refworld.org/reference/mission/unhrc/2017/en/116973	HRC mandate report on poverty and migrant rights in Saudi.
HRW – World Report 2025 (Migrant deaths)	https://www.ecoi.net/en/document/2120113.html	Documents abuses linked to PIF, forced labor, and mega-event exploitation.

Amnesty – “Eliminating Dissent” PDF (2023)	https://www.amnesty.org/en/wp-content/uploads/2023/10/MDE2369362023ENGLISH.pdf	Details crackdown on dissent during 2023 UPR cycle.
Guardian – Migrant deaths (AP)	https://apnews.com/article/8d913465c3de81c62412dcf5ec07f11c	Shows current migrant worker fatalities tied to mega-projects, UNHRC Item 2/7 relevance.
Reuters – UNHRC Council Seat Vote (2024)	https://www.reuters.com/world/middle-east/saudi-arabia-narrowly-fails-win-seat-un-human-rights-council-2024-10-09/	Shows international scrutiny and limited uptake by HRC member states.
Guardian – Worker safety & World Cup build crisis (2025)	https://www.theguardian.com/global-development/2025/may/14/pressure-grows-on-fifa-as-reports-warn-of-serious-risk-to-workers-amid-saudi-world-cup-building-boom	Latest civil/human rights concerns tied to UNHRC labor themes.

10 Unique Aspects: Saudi Arabia at UNHRC

- Hereditary Monarchy & Lack of Democratic Space:** Freedom House describes Saudi Arabia as an absolute monarchy where political freedom is nearly nonexistent—making it a standout case for the Council's attention.
- Repression of Dissent & Khashoggi Aftermath:** Ongoing arrests for social media posts and the still-unsolved Khashoggi murder continue to raise serious concerns for the UN Human Rights Council.
- UPR Participation vs Non-compliance:** While Saudi Arabia backs a number of UPR recommendations, organizations like HRW, Amnesty, and OHCHR point out a significant lack of progress in putting reforms into action.
- Systemic Migrant Worker Abuse:** The kafala system leads to forced labor, resulting in tragic deaths and severe exploitation, as pointed out by organizations like Human Rights Watch, Amnesty International, and the State Department.
- Mass Killings at Yemen Border:** Human Rights Watch has reported potential crimes against humanity related to the killings of migrants at the Saudi-Yemen border.
- Special Rapporteur Investigation of Excessive Use of Force:** HCHR's Special Rapporteur on counterterrorism and extreme poverty recently visited Saudi Arabia, bringing these important issues to the attention of the Human Rights Council for further examination.
- Mega-event Sportswashing Under Fire:** The conversation around the UNHRC has grown, especially with FIFA's 2034 bid, shedding light on issues like labor abuses and the hypocrisy in governance.
- Non-Ratification of Core HR Treaties:** Saudi Arabia has yet to ratify key treaties like the ICESCR and ICCPR, which presents a significant structural challenge highlighted by the treaty body tracking.

9. **Failure to Secure Council Seat Amid Criticism:** The outcome of the 2024 UNHRC election highlights growing international worries about Saudi Arabia's human rights situation.
 10. **Heightened UNHRC Attention & NGO Engagement:** Amnesty and Human Rights Watch made oral statements and released their "Eliminating Dissent" reports during the UPR cycles, playing a significant role in shaping the discussions within the Council.
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